The "Awesome Assam" campaign, launched to highlight the state's diverse attractions, has been instrumental in raising awareness about Assam as a tourist destination.

Additionally, two more 5-star hotel projects in Guwahati have been granted similar customised incentives.

Moreover, the Assam government has been actively participating in national and international tourism fairs and exhibitions to showcase the state's potential and attract more visitors. The "Awesome Assam" campaign, launched to highlight the state's diverse attractions, has been instrumental in raising awareness about Assam as a tourist destination. This campaign leverages various media platforms, including digital marketing, to reach a wider audience and showcase the unique experiences that Assam has to offer.

In addition to these initiatives, the government has also been working on developing niche tourism segments such as tea tourism, adventure tourism and river tourism. Tea tourism offers visitors a chance to explore the scenic tea gardens, stay in heritage bungalows, and learn about the tea-making process. A Tea Museum at Dibrugarh has also been completed. Adventure tourism includes activities like trekking, river rafting, and wildlife safaris, which are gaining popularity among young travellers. River tourism, cantered around the Brahmaputra, includes river cruises that offer a unique perspective of Assam's landscapes and culture.

To ensure a holistic development of the tourism sector, the Assam government has also been focusing on skill development and capacity building. Training programs for local guides, hospitality staff, and entrepreneurs are being conducted to enhance the quality of services provided to tourists. The government is also encouraging private investment in the tourism sector to further boost infrastructure and services.

Overall, Assam's tourism potential is immense, and with the proactive measures taken by the state government, the future looks promising. The combination of natural beauty, rich cultural heritage, strategic initiatives, and the newly granted industry status is set to place Assam on the global tourism map, attracting more visitors and contributing to the state's economic growth. ■

Homestay Harmony

The Amar Alohi Scheme aims at promoting tourism and cultural exchanges by helping locals to build local homestays

The Amar Alohi Scheme is an initiative by the Assam Tourism Department aimed at boosting the tourism sector in the state by promoting local homestays. The scheme focuses on providing tourists with authentic Assamese cultural experiences through their stays with local families. The primary goal is to offer tourists a unique, immersive experience while simultaneously generating additional income for locals, helping to preserve Assamese culture and traditions by allowing visitors to experience them first-hand. It aims to generate self-employment opportunities for educated youths in rural and semi-rural areas of tourism potential and importance.

Under the Amar Alohi Scheme, local homeowners are encouraged to register their homes as homestays, which are then listed on the Assam Tourism website and other promotional platforms, making it easier for tourists to find and book authentic Assamese accommodations. The Assam Tourism Department provides necessary support and training to homeowners, including guidance on hospitality, hygiene standards, and marketing techniques to ensure a pleasant and memorable experience for guests. By promoting homestays, the scheme aims to distribute the economic benefits of tourism more widely across the state, especially to rural and less developed areas, leading to community development and improved living standards for residents.

The scheme encourages cultural exchange between tourists and local hosts, allowing tourists to participate in local customs, festivals, and daily life activities, while hosts gain exposure to different cultures and perspectives. The Amar Alohi Scheme aligns with the principles of sustainable tourism by minimizing the environmental impact of tourism through utilizing existing infrastructure and promoting conservation of cultural heritage and natural resources.

Phase I

- Launch year: 2017-18
- 96 applications were received of which 29 got selected after proper scrutiny and approval of the authority.
- All 29 homestays are running commercially



Phase II

- Launch year: 2018-19.
- 81 applications were received of which 34 got selected after proper scrutiny and approval of the authority.
- All 34 homestays are running commercially



Phase III

- Launch year 2022-23
- In the third phase the objective was to help create a group/cluster of minimum 10 homestays, as part of "Community Based Organizations" near a tourist spot
- 34 applications were received of which five got selected after proper scrutiny and approval of the authority.
- Honourable Minister of Tourism Jayanta Malla Baruah distributed five sanction letters on February 29, 2024.
- Work is in progress in all five Community Based Organizations

